across India, often in reaction to Brahminism – was creating social upheavals.[32]

Brahmins were, as they remain, a dominant social and cultural force in sixteenth-century Hindustan. The Jain poet Banarasidas relates a wonderfully telling anecdote of the great reverence that brahmins were accorded. Once, writes Banarasi, he was travelling through a forest with two men when they were accosted by the chief, *chaudhari*, of a gang of thieves. Thinking on their feet, Banarasi and his friends pretended to be brahmins – they chanted shlokas, fashioned *janeus* out of yarn, put tilaks of mud on their foreheads and thus made their escape. Indeed, the chaudhari escorted them to safety himself, saying, 'Revered pandits, / Come with me, let me show you the way out of this forest.'[33]

Much like his court ulema, then, the brahmins in Akbar's court guarded their authority. The modern historian Pushpa Prasad tells of how brahmins 'jealous' of Akbar's admiration for a Jain acharya called Vijayasen Suri spread a rumour that Jains were atheists.[34]

As Akbar would do with the Jains, so, now, he did with the Sikhs: he arranged a debate, to which Guru Amar Das sent Jetha to argue against brahmin scholars. Jetha, who would be the fourth Guru, Ram Das, and whose celebrated hymns comprise a significant proportion of the Sikh holy book, the Guru Granth Sahib, ended his argument with a suitably poetic flourish: 'The Brahmans claim to be equal to God. The Guru maketh no such boast, for he knoweth that he is God's slave.'

Akbar was pleased by the young Sikh's rhetorical skill, but advised Jetha to visit Haridwar and placate the Hindus. He also promised that Jetha and his party would not have to pay the pilgrim tax. 'This,' write Hoyland and Banerjee, 'probably resulted in the total remission of the pilgrim tax . . . [in] 1563.'[35]

Abul Fazl, meanwhile, has Akbar abolishing the pilgrim tax with heroic flourish. The emperor was out lion-hunting near Mathura, had levelled 'five with the dust by arrow and bullets' and taken a sixth alive (there were 'a thousand wonderings', writes the historian). Mathura may not have lions any longer, but it remains, as it was, a pilgrimage site; so Akbar decided to mix 'worship with pleasure' by remitting the pilgrimage tax, declaring that no matter how misguided a sect might be, 'to put a stumbling block in